

Lab 2: Compare Prompt, Context and Harness Controls

Duration: 35 minutes

Topic: 1

Objective

Turn an ambiguous request into a measurable task contract and a minimal context package for an agent.

Deliverable

A prompt-context comparison, AGENTS.md context file, acceptance rubric and a redacted test transcript.

Prerequisites

- A trainer-approved laptop and classroom workspace.
- Use only fictional data supplied in this lab.
- Do not paste API keys, customer data or personal information into evidence.
- Lab 1 completed or the trainer demonstration environment.

Procedure

Step 1: Read scenario.md and highlight the business outcome, prohibited actions and missing evidence.

Step 2: Run the ambiguous prompt once in a fresh session and record why the result cannot be accepted.

```
hermes
```

Step 3: Complete task-contract.md with outcome, inputs, authority, acceptance evidence, stop conditions and rollback.

Step 4: Edit AGENTS.md so the agent receives the fictional organisation rules at session start.

Step 5: Start a fresh session in this folder and give the improved task contract.

```
hermes
```

Step 6: Compare the two outputs using acceptance-rubric.md; do not reward verbosity.

Step 7: Remove any sensitive or credential-like content from the transcript and save only the evidence needed for review.

Step 8: Run the verifier and explain which improvement came from prompting and which came from context engineering.

```
python3 verify.py
```

Acceptance test

The improved run names its evidence, respects the no-send rule and passes every acceptance item; the learner distinguishes prompt wording from context and runtime authority.

Evidence checklist

- ☐ Commands or configuration used (with secrets redacted)
- ☐ Screenshot or generated-file evidence
- ☐ Acceptance test result
- ☐ One failure and how it was resolved
- ☐ Reflection: one control or improvement

Safety and cleanup

- Use fictional data only.
- Never submit .env, tokens, keys or personal information.
- Stop classroom gateways and remove recurring jobs after evidence capture.

References

- [Official course page](#)
- [Hermes Agent repository](#)
- [Hermes Agent documentation](#)
- [Hermes tools reference](#)
- [Hermes toolsets reference](#)
- [Hermes skills](#)
- [Hermes memory](#)
- [Hermes context files](#)
- [Hermes security](#)
- [Hermes subagents](#)
- [Hermes Kanban](#)
- [Hermes video tools](#)
- Generative AI for Business Innovation — Reference ebook by Brajesh De, 2026
- The Agentic AI Revolution — Reference ebook by Will Hawkins and Nancie Calder, 2025
- Mastering AI Agents — Reference ebook by Marcus Lighthaven, 2025
- Untangling AI — Reference ebook by Matt Kesby, 2026